Watchlog

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Summary

I'm asking for approval to try Watchlog, a tool I built to speed up our log entries, with IT looking it over before it goes any further.

Every shift is typing the same entries: door checks, audits, jackpots, refusals, soft count steps, AML alerts. Each one has standard wording and a few details that change. Watchlog keeps the standard wording ready. You type a short code, fill in the details, and the finished entry goes into iTrak. You still read it over and save it yourself, same as now.

By my count it saves about 2,000 keystrokes and around 14 minutes a shift, or roughly 42 hours a year per operator. I haven't timed it yet, and measuring it properly is one of the reasons for the pilot. The time saved goes back into watching the floor.

What I type	What ends up in the log
`;interior` (9 keystrokes)	Security Supervisor performed interior door check
`;evict`, check the 3 boxes, Enter (9 keystrokes if the defaults are right)	Report opened on behalf of Security. The Security Supervisor approached a guest at Main Entrance for showing signs of intoxication. The guest was escorted off the gaming floor and given a 24 hour Trespass. The guest left without further incident.

For the pilot I'd need:

- The supervisors, picked by management, to approve the template wording. The shared file would sit in a SharePoint folder that all of them have access to.
- IT to look at how passwords are stored, the automatic logins, installing AutoHotkey, starting the tool when Windows starts, and the shift journal (a copy of each entry kept for 30 days).

Security has its own section further down. In short: passwords are kept in Windows Credential Manager and never in a file, the tool doesn't connect to the internet or send anything anywhere, and a built-in report shows exactly what it has saved on any PC.

What it does

It's a small Windows program written in AutoHotkey, a free automation tool that has been around for years. It sits by the clock as a small teal icon and can start with Windows. I've been building and testing it myself since October 13. Version 3.0 was the first one set up for the team, and it's on 3.3.0 now.

Log entries

There are 36 templates so far. Every code starts with a semicolon so it never goes off in the middle of normal typing, and the entry appears as soon as the code is typed.

Area	Codes
Incidents and reviews	`;jack` jackpot · `;audit` employee audit · `;medical` · `;evict` trespass · `;face` facial recognition alert
Start and end of shift	`;start` · `;end` (remembers which bay you were on last)
Security routines	`;interior` · `;exterior` door checks · `;parking` patrol · `;noid` · `;insuf` · `;intox` · `;expired` refused entry · `;selfex` self-exclusion · `;inventory` · `;account` review · `;drop` table drop
Tables	`;open` · `;close` · `;auto` auto-close · `;cards` card change · `;fill` table fill · `;player` player log
Slots	`;bv` emergency BV pull · `;abandon` abandoned credits returned · `;found` abandoned credits taken to Security · `;aml` AML alert · `;maint` maintenance · `;mfill` ATM and NRT fill
Soft count	`;countstep` step by step · `;counttables` · `;countslots` · `;countpull`
Other	`;destroy` card destruction · `;badge` visitor badge

If you can't remember a code, Ctrl+Alt+Space opens a search. Type a word like trespass or ambulance, look at the wording, and press Enter. Ctrl+Alt+H brings up a cheat sheet with every code on it.

Forms for the details

When an entry has details that change, a small form pops up with a box for each one. Tab moves between boxes, Enter puts the entry in and Esc cancels. The form takes care of the fiddly parts:

- Times fill themselves in (audits get the time plus 20 minutes), and typing 2130 gives 21:30.
- Money and percentages come out formatted, so 10000 becomes $10,000 and 67 becomes 67%.
- The medical outcome, trespass reason and length, employee job title and table number are picked from a list instead of typed. Typing 202 picks FB202.
- Machine numbers come out in capitals, and an employee number you've just copied fills itself in.
- A BV pull, table fill or machine fill can list several machines or tables in one entry.
- An empty box leaves XXXXX in the entry, so a missing detail is easy to spot. A preview at the bottom of the form shows the finished entry as you type.

Everything around the logging

- `;t`, `;dd` and `;dt` type the time, the date, or both.
- Logins: a short code types the username and password and presses Enter. For SDS, a pop-up reminds you about 55 minutes after each login.
- Ctrl+Alt+L opens everything for the start of shift in a few seconds: the work websites, iTrak facial recognition in Edge, AlertGrid, SDS and CMP, skipping anything that's already open. Ctrl+Alt+Shift+L closes it all at the end of the shift, after confirming. It logs out of SDS properly first instead of just closing it, and Ctrl+Alt+K does that SDS logout on its own.
- Ctrl+Alt and a letter switches to SDS, CMP, Teams, Outlook or Chrome.
- Ctrl+Alt+Q adds a quick note, with a tag like #todo if you want one.
- The shift journal saves a copy of every entry you put in, with the time. Ctrl+Alt+J shows how many of each log you've done and gives you a one-line summary for the End of Shift entry, like "Shift summary (18:20 - 05:47): 47 logs. 12 Audit, ...". If iTrak loses an entry, you can copy it back from the journal.

Using it as a team (new in 3.0)

Since version 3.0 it's set up for more than one operator. Everyone reads the same template file from a SharePoint folder, so the whole team writes from the same approved wording. When the supervisors change something, every bay picks it up as SharePoint syncs, without restarting anything. If SharePoint can't be reached, the tool keeps using the last copy it had and says so. Each PC also checks that it's on the same version as the rest of the team, and says if it needs an update. When a new version of the program is put in the shared folder, each PC asks before updating itself, checks that the new file works, and keeps a backup of the old one.

Setting up a new operator takes about 5 minutes. I make a clean copy from the tray menu (it leaves out my settings and anything personal), they put it in their Documents and open it, and a welcome window asks for their logins and where the team file is. After that, changes are made in a Settings window rather than by editing files, and there's a one-page quick start guide in the folder. Operators can add a few codes of their own in a separate file, but those can't override a team template.

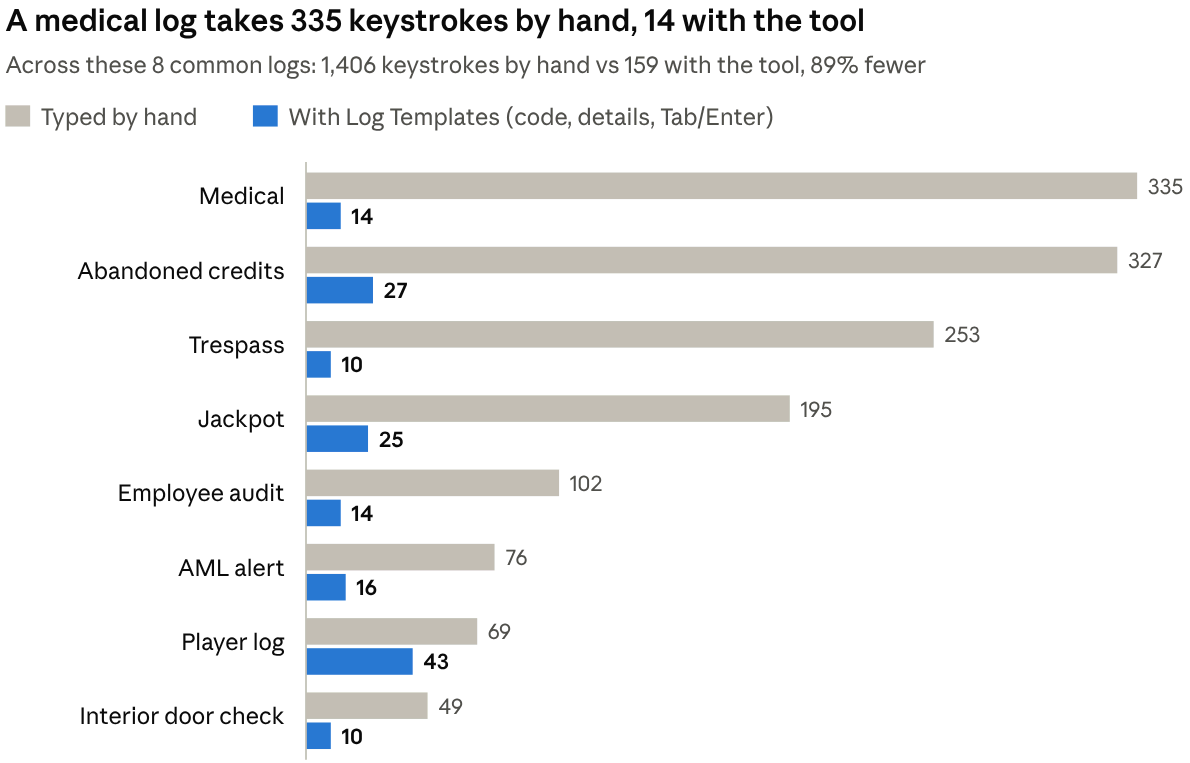
Why it helps

- It's faster. A typical entry takes 5 to 25 keystrokes instead of 50 to 300 or more.
- Entries are more consistent. When everyone works from the same file, entries read the same no matter who wrote them, which should make reviews and audits easier.
- There are fewer mistakes. Times come from the PC clock, numbers are formatted the same way every time, and the standard wording can't pick up typos. It won't stop someone saving an incomplete entry, but the XXXXX makes it hard to miss.
- Training is easier. New operators can find a template by any word in it, and the templates show how each kind of entry should be worded.
- It's easier on the hands and on concentration over a long shift.
- It's easy to keep up to date. If a procedure changes, one edit to the shared file updates every bay.

It works in anything you can type into, including iTrak through Citrix, because all it does is paste text where the cursor is. Other departments that write repetitive reports, like security or the cage, could use it with their own template file.

Time saved (my estimates)

I worked these out by counting the keystrokes for each template, typed in full versus with the tool, over a typical shift. They haven't been timed yet.



Keystrokes for each template, typed in full and with the tool (counted on version 2.4).

The longer the entry, the more it saves. The player log saves the least because most of it is details you still have to type.

A typical shift

Task	Per shift	By hand	With the tool	Saved
Log entries (a mix of 18 templates)	30 entries	2,207 keystrokes	388 keystrokes	1,819
Logins (one app every hour)	10 logins	about 240 keystrokes	about 50 keystrokes	about 190
Time stamps	10 stamps	60 keystrokes	20 keystrokes	40

Task	Per shift	By hand	With the tool	Saved
Total typing		**about 2,500**	**about 460**	**about 2,050 (82% less)**
Opening apps and sites at start of shift	3 apps, 7 sites	about 3 minutes	1 key, about 5 seconds	about 3 min
Closing everything at end of shift	about 11 programs	about 1 minute	1 key and a confirm	about 1 min

That's about 14 minutes a shift: around 10 minutes of typing at 40 words a minute, plus about 4 minutes of opening and closing apps.

Period	Keystrokes saved	Time saved
Per shift	about 2,050	about 14 minutes
Per month (15 shifts)	about 31,000	about 3.5 hours
Per year (180 shifts)	about 369,000	about 42 hours
A team of 6 operators, per year	about 2.2 million	about 250 hours

How I got these numbers:

- The shift I counted has 30 entries: start and end of shift, 2 each of door checks, patrols, jackpots, AML alerts, facial recognition alerts, no-ID refusals, account reviews and card changes, 4 audits, and 1 each of a table drop, table close, table fill, player log, medical and BV pull. A busier shift would save more.
- "By hand" means typing the whole entry. "With the tool" means the code, only the details that change, and a Tab or Enter for each box.
- I counted on an earlier version (2.4). Codes no longer need a space after them, so the real numbers are a little better.
- I didn't count fixing typos, looking up wording, redoing entries that get sent back, or logging back in after a missed hourly login. Those would only add to it.
- The team row assumes 6 operators doing the same mix of entries.

It could look better than it really is for anyone who already copies and pastes from old entries, and worse for anyone who looks up wording or fixes a lot of typos. Timing real entries on the pilot bays would settle it.

Tracking it for real

Since version 3.2.0 the tool keeps its own count, so these estimates can be replaced with real numbers. For each entry it works out how much went in compared with how much I typed. An empty box counts as nothing saved, so the numbers aren't inflated. Logins and time stamps are counted too, and the time comes from 40 words a minute. Tray menu > Time saved shows logs, logins, keystrokes and time saved for this shift, today, the last 7 days, the last 30 days and the total, and Copy report puts it on the clipboard. It only stores numbers, never the text of a log.

Security and saved information

Since security comes first here, this is everything the tool saves and where. It doesn't save anything else.

What	Where it's kept	Who can see it	How long
Passwords	Windows Credential Manager on that PC, where Windows keeps its own saved passwords	Only that Windows user. Never put in a file, synced or shown on screen	Until the login is removed in Settings, which deletes the password too
Login codes, usernames and settings	settings.ini in the operator's own folder	The operator	Until changed. There are no passwords in it. If someone types one in, the tool moves it into Credential Manager the next time it starts
Shift journal (time, template and text of each entry, never logins)	The operator's Documents\Shift Journal folder, which syncs to their own OneDrive	The operator	30 days, then deleted automatically. It can be set anywhere from 7 days to a year, set to keep only times and template names, or turned off

What	Where it's kept	Who can see it	How long
Quick notes	Quick Notes.md in the operator's Documents	The operator	Until they delete them
Activity log (when the tool started, settings changes, template updates, which login was used, errors)	That PC only	That Windows user	Trimmed automatically. Never passwords or log text
Last login time for each username	The Windows registry, under the user's own settings	That Windows user	Only used for the hourly reminder
Template wording	One file in a SharePoint folder, plus a backup copy on each PC	Whoever the folder is shared with. Only the people management allows can edit it	SharePoint keeps earlier versions and who changed them

A few more things worth knowing:

- It doesn't connect to the internet or send anything anywhere. Its files only reach another PC through the operator's own OneDrive and SharePoint, under our normal Microsoft 365 permissions. (Ctrl+Alt+L opens the work websites in the browser, the same as clicking a bookmark.)
- It doesn't record what you type. It only watches for its own codes.
- It only types a password when that login's code is typed, and a login can be locked to one program.
- It doesn't change iTrak or any other system. It types what the operator would have typed, and the operator still saves the entry.
- The copy it makes for sharing never includes anyone's settings, passwords, journal or notes.

And how to check all of this:

- Security and status, in the tray menu, shows everything above for the PC you're on: which logins have a saved password, whether a password has ended up in settings.ini, where the templates came from, the journal setting, and how many shift files there are. The Copy report button puts it on the clipboard so it can be sent to a supervisor or IT.

- Each PC shows a short check code for its template wording, something like 1A2B-3C4D. Two PCs with the same code have exactly the same wording, so it's easy to confirm every bay is on the approved version.
- When the shared wording changes, each PC shows a notice and writes the old and new check codes to its activity log.

Setup and what IT would need to look at

Each operator keeps their own copy of the program folder in their OneDrive Documents, so it follows them from bay to bay. The template wording comes from the shared file.

File	What it is
Watchlog.ahk	The program
templates.txt	The wording of every template, in plain English. The team copy lives on SharePoint and the supervisors look after it
my-templates.txt	Optional extra codes for one operator, kept separate from the approved wording
settings.ini	That operator's login codes and usernames (no passwords), app shortcuts and start and end of shift lists. Created by the welcome window
LaunchWork.bat	The websites that open at the start of shift
QUICK START.txt and README.txt	A one-page setup guide and the full guide

What IT would need to approve:

- Storing passwords in Windows Credential Manager and having the tool type them in
- Installing AutoHotkey v2 on the bay PCs
- Starting the tool when Windows starts
- The shift journal keeping a copy of log text for 30 days
- Who gets edit access to the SharePoint template folder

Next steps

Version 3.3.0 is built and I've been testing it myself since October 13. If it's approved, this is how I'd see it going:

1. Management and IT sign off on the pilot.
2. The supervisors go through and approve the wording of each template.
3. The approved file goes in a SharePoint folder that all the supervisors have access to.
4. We time a sample of common entries by hand and with the tool.
5. We look at the results and decide whether to roll it out further.

I'm happy to show it working to anyone who'd like to see it.